I Love Girl

By Simon Rich

INTRODUCTION

(INTRO should be spoken very expansively, perhaps with a British accent)

*Greetings, my eloquent and verbose audience of (*insert number of audience members*). Our vocabulary has become quite extensive over the years, with beautiful words like dalliance and evocative. Once upon a time, we were much less eloquent . . .*

Lord Byron's
"She walks in beauty, like the night
Of cloudless climes and starry skies,
And all that's best of dark and bright
Meets in her aspect and her eyes."
was once simply . . . . I Love Girl by Simon Rich.

Demeanor, body position, vocal qualities transform into the caricature of the early caveman.

I am Oog. I love Girl. Girl loves Boog. It is bad situation.

Boog and I are very different people. For example, we have different jobs. My job is Rock Thrower. There are many rocks all over the place and people are always tripping on them. So when I became a man, at age eleven, the Old Person said to me, "Get rid of all the rocks." Since that day, ten years ago, whenever it is light outside, I am gathering rocks and throwing them off the cliff.

Boog's job is Artist. When he became a man, the Old Person said to him, "Cut down the trees so we have space to live." But Boog did not want to do this, so now he smears paint inside caves. He calls his smears "pictures." Everybody likes to look at them. But the person who likes to look at them most is Girl.

I love Girl. There are many women in the world. By last count, seven. But she is the only one I ever loved. Girl lives on Black Mountain. It is called Black Mountain because (1) it is mountain and (2) it is covered in black rocks. Every day, Girl has to climb over the rocks to get to the river. It is too hard. So one day I decided, "I will clear a path from Girl's cave to the river."

I have been working on Girl's path for many years, picking up the black rocks and carrying them

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away. I never throw her rocks off the cliff like normal rocks. Instead, I put them in a pile next to my cave. I like to look at the pile, because it reminds me of how I am helping Girl.

I am afraid to talk to Girl. If she found out it was me clearing all the rocks, I'm sure she would say something to me like "Hello" or "Hi there." And then I would be in trouble. I am not so good at making words.

Boog is very good at making words. For example, last week he showed off his new picture at the Main Cave. Everyone was expecting it to be a horse or a bear (all his pictures so far have been horses, bears, or a mix of horses and bears). But this picture was not of any animal. It was just a bunch of red streaks. People were angry.

"I wanted animals," the Old Person said. "Where are the animals?" It was bad situation. I thought that Boog would lose his job or maybe be killed by stones. But then Boog stood on a rock and spoke.

"My art is smart," he said. "And anyone who does not get it is stupid."

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Everyone was quiet. We looked at the Old Person to see what he would say. The Old Person squinted at the red streaks for a while. Then he rubbed his chin and said, "Oh, yes, now I get it. It is smart. People who do not get it are stupid." A few seconds later, everyone else got it.

The only person who did not get it was me. My beard began to sweat. I was scared that someone would ask me to make words about the picture. I headed slowly for the exit. I was almost out of the cave when Boog pointed his finger at me. "Do you like it, Oog?" Everyone stopped making words and looked at me. "Why don't you explain it to us?"

I felt a burning on my skin. It was sort of like when you fall into a cooking fire and your body catches on fire. I looked at my feet and people started laughing. I looked up at Girl to see if she was one of the ones laughing. She was not (thank Gods). But she could hear all the other people laughing and that was just as bad.

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The next day, I decided to become an Artist. "I am going to make a picture," I told the others. "A good one."

"Who are you going to show it to?" Moog said. "Your mother?" Everyone laughed.

"No," I said. "I will show it to Girl." No one made words after that.

I have never spoken to Girl, but one time she spoke to me. It was a long time ago, when we were still children.

It was the first day of school and we were learning to count. It was confusing. I am very good at some numbers. I understand "one" and "two" very well and I am O.K. with "three." But when it gets to higher math, like "four" or "five," I have trouble.

The Old Person had told us each to make a pile of five rocks. I did not know how many that was and it was getting to be my turn. It was bad situation. "Don't worry," she said. "I will help you." The Old Person was about to look at my pile when Girl stood up and pointed into the forest. "Predator!" she yelled.

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By the time we came back from the Hiding Cave, it was night. I wanted to thank Girl, but I did not know which words to make. So I said nothing.

Girl has a small head, so it is very strange how she fits so many things inside of it. She knows all the numbers: "six," "eight"—you name it. But she also knows other things nobody else knows.

One time, I followed her down to the river. She was hunting fish in the normal way, by jabbing a stick in the water. After a long time, she caught a small flat fish. I assumed she would do the normal thing (rip off the head and eat the body), but instead she did the strangest thing I have ever seen. She put the stick—with the small fish still on it—back into the river. A short time later, she pulled the stick out. A bigger fish was on the stick. I do not understand how Girl did this.

But I have thought a lot about what I saw, and I have developed a theory: she is a witch who knows magic. Even though she is probably a witch, I still love her. My mother says that when you love someone you love them despite their flaws. For example, my father was not so

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good at hunting after a monster ate his arms. But my mother continued to love him.

Girl must really love Boog, because he has many flaws. He never smiles or shares his meat with other people. He is rude to the Old Person and will not rub his feet. Boog's worst flaw, though, is that he disrespects Girl. He makes his voice big and snaps his fingers. It is like he is talking to a dog.

I decided to make my picture of a horse, because I knew that was a thing. It took a long time . . . my mother was watching over my shoulder the whole time and making words. "You are bad at this," she said. "You should stop because you are bad."

Finally, after many days of work, I finished my picture. I was about to add my handprint when I heard a familiar laugh. I turned around; Boog was there. "The picture is bad," he said. "It stinks. I do not like it."

I sighed. My plan had been to show my picture to Girl. But I started to worry that she would not like it. The reviews, so far, were not great.

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Moog said, "It is the worst picture made yet by a human."

The Old Person said, "I always knew you were dumb. It is known by everyone. But this picture makes me realize you are even dumber than it was believed."

One of the main problems, people explained, was that I had not given the horse any legs. Also, I had given it hands, forgetting that a horse has no hands. I was proud of the picture when I painted it, but people's words had made me ashamed. I decided it was best to destroy it, before Girl found out about it.

I grabbed some empty bladders and brought up water from the river. I was about to splash the painting when I heard that laugh again. "Don't destroy it yet," Boog said. "There is someone who wants to see it."
He grabbed Girl by the arm and thrust her in front of my picture. It was bad situation.

"Tell Oog what you think of it," Boog said.

"I do not like it," Girl said. "You are not smart. I love Boog and not you." I stood there in silence. Hot water came out of my eyeballs.

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Boog walked over to my pile of black rocks, picked one up, and hurled it against my picture. "Let's go," he said to Girl. She started to follow him. As she was leaving, she paused to take a rock from my pile. I was afraid she would throw it at my picture, like Boog had. But instead she held it up to her face and squinted at it, [then] followed him into the woods, still holding the rock in her hand.

My mother woke me in the night. "A monster is here to murder us," she said. I nodded. This is usual occurrence.

We were silent for a while; soon, I heard a strange sound. The monster was throwing rocks against the cave, one after the other. I took my kill stick and headed outside. I saw a figure in the shadows and was about to charge it when the moon appeared suddenly between the clouds. "Girl?"

She was standing on the edge of the forest, a black rock in her hand. "Sorry if I scared you," she said. "I came to say thank you."

I was confused. "For what?"

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"For clearing me a path."

"How did you know it was me?"

"I took a rock from your pile and compared it with the ones on my mountain. They're the same kind."

I walked cautiously toward her. "Are you a witch?" I asked.

She laughed. "I'm not a witch! I just used common sense. I mean, there are thousands of black rocks piled up next to your cave." I was still confused. She put her hand on my arm and the hairs on it stood up. "Thank you for clearing all the rocks," she said, looking into my eyes. "It is a good path. You are good at clearing the rocks." For the second time that night, hot water came out of my eyeballs. "I'm sorry I said those mean things about your picture," Girl said. "Boog made me."

"Does that mean you like my Art?" I asked.

She looked at my horse and hesitated. "It's interesting," she said. "But you know what I really like? Your rock pile." She walked over to it. "It's sort of like a sculpture."

"What is sculpture?"

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"Like a picture in three dimensions."

Much time passed in silence. "I know I am not smart like Boog. I do not understand Art and I am bad with the numbers. But I will work hard to clear the rocks for you. And when you have child I will clear the rocks for the child. " I paused to catch my breath. It was the most words I had ever made at one time.

"What about Boog?" she said.

I thought about it for a moment. "I will murder him," I said. She smiled and kissed me on the cheek. It was like it had been in my dreams.

We made many words that night. Girl explained that she never really loved Boog. He just seemed like her only option. The other six men on earth, including me, had been too afraid. I confessed that I did not understand Boog's last picture and she laughed. "No one did," she said. "Not even Boog."

The next day, I took a large rock and struck it against Boog's head so that his skull cracked open and he died. Afterward, Girl and I went swimming. We have

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decided to have many children: one, two—maybe even a higher number.

I love Girl. Girl loves me. It is good situation.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Simon Rich
Book: The Last Girlfriend on Earth
ISBN: 978-0316219389
Publisher: Back Bay Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2014

AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier